

Guidelines for writing the short essays

1. What is an essay?

"An essay is a reduced size, non-exhaustive paper (piece of writing) on a well defined subject, developed with original means."

An essay is, by no means, a self-contained document that exhaustively debates a subject. In other words, **the short essay is NOT a tutorial NOR a survey**. In writing short essays, you should presume that readers are familiar with the subject so that you shouldn't explain everything. Readers are interested just in your opinion on the discussed issue.

2. What should you do?

There are several tasks you should fulfill:

- Read carefully the requirements and the proposed topics
- Collect the material together
- Read and find an idea
- Construct the plan of the essay
- Write the essay
- Check against the requirements

3. Collecting the material

The short essays are intended to stimulate you doing a documentary research. This includes finding the most trusted sources of information, identifying the most relevant papers and Web materials, collecting objective information (in terms of figures, experiment results, results of scientific proofs, etc.), comparing results and opinions, extracting the essential from some documents.

So, your first task is to get the material together. The material comes in two kinds: **primary** and **secondary** sources. Primary sources in this case are scientific papers that present a new solution to known problems in the domain (e.g. a new protocol, a new technology, a new approach, etc.) Secondary sources are survey papers including works of criticism on papers in the first category. Works in both categories are important. In particular, reading critics can give you an idea of what the state of critical opinion is about a subject and to save you re-inventing the wheel.

The Web is rapidly becoming a fantastic resource: easily available, full of material, and with an answer to every question. However, there are problems, and you should use the Web carefully. In fact, selecting proper material from the web is a proof of your knowledge in the domain (and, obviously, graded accordingly).

4. Read and find an idea

When you have collected the articles you will need to read them. You will make a collection of your ideas about the subject while reading. If you do write them down, you will probably think of some more ideas while you are writing. Analyze them and choose one that seems to you the most interesting.

5. Construct the plan

The **plan** you construct should be in the form of an indented outline. You should start with a **draft** like the following one and improve it while writing the essay:

Main heading
Short abstract
 Subheading 1
 Notes on subheading 1
 Subheading 2
 Notes on subheading 2
 ...
 Conclusion
 Notes on conclusion
References

6. Write the essay

The **structure** of the essay will be the following:

- Title
- Abstract
- Body
- References.

Your idea (opinion) must be reflected in the **title** and clearly explained in the **abstract**, which should define precisely the idea you want to defend and develop on it the rest of the paper.

Sustain your assertions with proved, reported results; do not base the essay exclusively on your own direct experience (unless you have published results on the issue attacked in the essay). You must rely on and cite a **minimum of 5 scholarly references**, such as articles from academic journals or books or scholarly Web sites. Support all your assertions on facts and conclusions with examples from credible sources.

For all material used verbatim, you must include quotation marks (don't abuse of them). Whether you are summarizing, paraphrasing, or quoting directly, cite the source. Please note that only a limited amount of material can be quoted, summarized, or paraphrased from sources. You are to provide original analysis, synthesis, and evaluation of information.

Present different opinions found in literature and then present your own opinion.

7. Check against the requirements

Requirements on the essay's format

The **abstract** should be of less than half a page. The length of the **body** must be around 1500 words, or approximately 3 single-spaced pages. Figures, tables, data sets, and other similar supporting information should be put in the body part of the essay. The **References** will be counted separately.

Requirements on the essay's style

The short essay has the intent of grasping your critical thinking of putting together information and further developing your writing skills. Keep in mind that the short essays are not reviews of a

domain, nor abstracts of longer papers mentioned in References. Instead, a short essay should state an idea and tries to give the rationales to sustain it. Consequently, you should:

- use paragraphs to highlight the structure of the text and keep the reader's attention
- discuss each rationale (to sustain the idea) in a new paragraph
- avoid single sentence paragraphs and also long paragraphs, for example one page paragraphs
- synthesize the results using tables and / or figures
- restrict your attention to a narrow, specific aspect rather than exploring a large domain.
- use short sentences (without abusing of this style)
- eliminate redundancy, wordiness, jargon, evasiveness, etc.
- be precise and concise.